

modated as the Opposition candidate for a second term as the veep. Should Kalam decline to contest, then Shekhawat would, as per current plans, contest against Patil and NDA leaders are confident that the Third Front will support him, given the vice-president's warm cross-party contacts.

In today's slippery political terrain, it is easy to understand Sonia's high premium on loyalty. After all, this is not about the presidential elections. Rather, the target is the next general elections, due in 2009. In this era of coalition politics, with no party getting outright majority, it is the president who gets to make the crucial decision as to who gets the first chance to form the next government: the single largest party or the single largest coalition. And does this have to be a pre-poll or a post-poll alliance? For instance, in 1996 the then president Shankar Dayal Sharma invited Vajpayee as leader of the single largest party even though the BJP was well short of the halfway mark. The stakes are too high for the Congress to suddenly give up an opportunity of having its 'own person' in Raisina



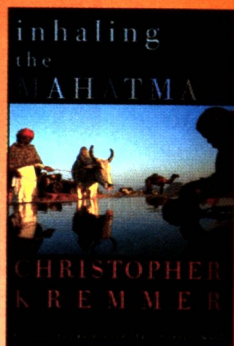
IF KALAM DECLINES TO CONTEST, NDA LEADERS ARE CONFIDENT THAT SHEKHAWAT'S CROSS-PARTY TIES WILL SWING THE VOTES FOR HIM.

TEAM PLAYER: Shekhawat is ready to step down if Kalam joins the fray

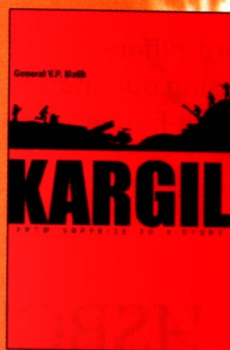
Hill. Jayalalithaa has called Patil's candidature a "political joke". In retaliation, Lalu says that it is the Opposition that is playing a joke on President Kalam. But with petty politics and one-upmanship dominating the race for the country's most impartial and apolitical office, it seems as if the joke is on the entire political establishment. ■



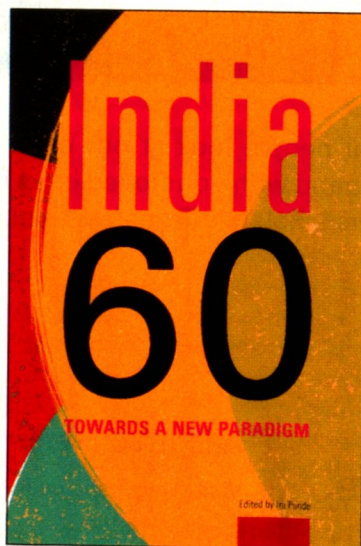
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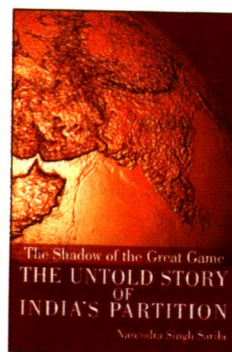
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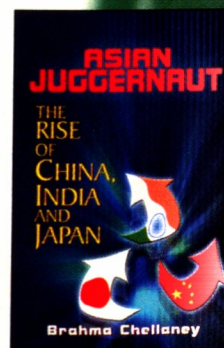
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